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Icon SPEAK

For Bhutia, Lajong's success is a great break for the North-east

Baichung Bhutia's rise to international fame from a tiny backward village of Sikkim is almost like a fairytale. This iconic player believes that Lajong's entry into the I-League is great news for the region. "They now have a team to play for and do not have to be desperate to travel to bigger clubs to be in the limelight. I am very happy for them. Lajong is a spirited young team and I am sure they will get better with time," he says.

Had his own journey been easier if there had been a local club closer to home to start out with? Bhutia remains a man of wide ambition and says he is not sure of that. "It may have helped, but I still may have gone for a big club," he laughs.

But if Lajong can maintain its journey ahead, then for the future Sunil Chhetris or Gourmangi Singhs, the road will be much easier.



TEAM SHILLONG LAJONG FC (ABOVE): A VAST AND DEDICATED ARMY OF VOCIFEROUS SUPPORTERS KEEP THE TEAM GOING

ready to hang in there and ready to do what it takes to make a further impact in the future.

Larsing believes the team's strength lies in the fact that the club has a huge talent pool. Lajong is committed towards harnessing and nurturing local players. Even though there are foreigners in the team, there is an effort to give the local players prominence by making them play upfront as strikers. The Larsing family, whose business interests are spread over construction, hospitality and event management, looks after its financial needs. With a place sealed in the I-League, corporate sponsorships are also in the kitty and the players have become role models for youngsters of the area who have now begun to look at the game as a means to a better life without having